

PIANO MAN FILL

The Billy Joel Fill You Can Use Everywhere

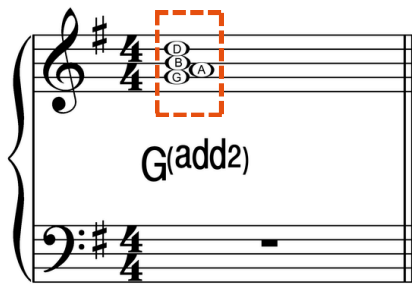


Introduction from Adam

This Billy Joel piano fill is one of my go-to moves for bringing chord progressions to life. It's simple to play, comes straight from 'Piano Man,' and once you understand the idea behind it, you can tweak and shape it to fit whatever you're playing.

Step #1

Build the Shape video 2:13



The framework for this fill comes from a Gadd9 chord — a G major triad with the 9th (A) added. I like to think of this as a G major **colour chord**.

Rather than playing the notes as a block chord, we turn them into small melodic ideas by moving between them.



You can reorder the notes, try different rhythms, or even use grace notes to give the fill a bit more character. Below are a few simple permutations to explore.



Now let's apply this idea to a simple chord progression in the key of G major. In this example, we're using chords **ii, iii, IV and V** — a really common movement that works well for experimenting with these kinds of fills.

In this example, we've created a version of the fill and then repeated it the second time an octave lower. Notice how this simple idea immediately adds **colour** and **movement** to what was previously a very plain chord progression.



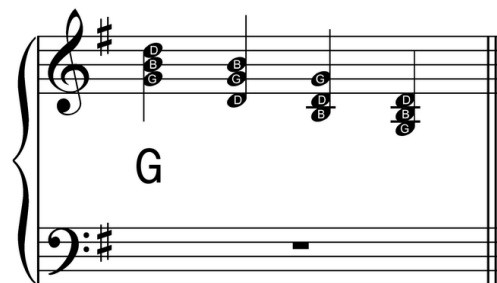
"There's a bit of syncopation in this one, so don't worry if it doesn't click straight away — give it a little time and it'll start to feel natural!"

Step #2

Make it Flow

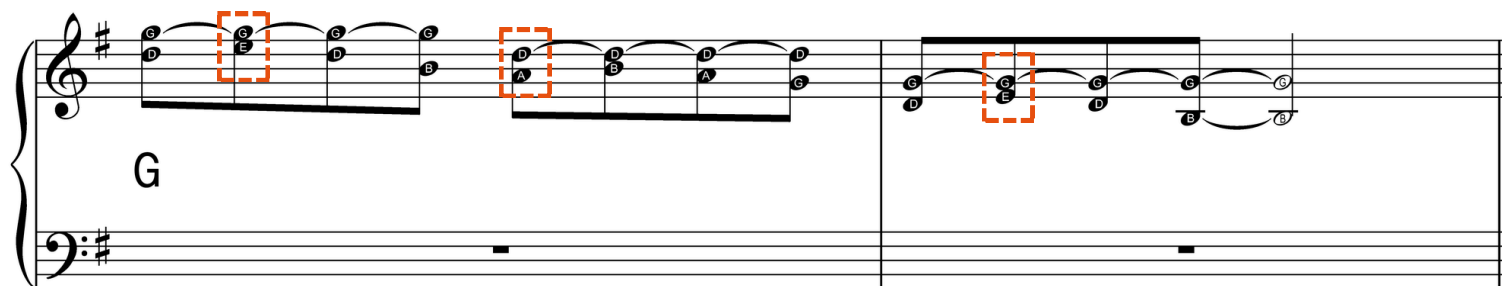


video 4:00

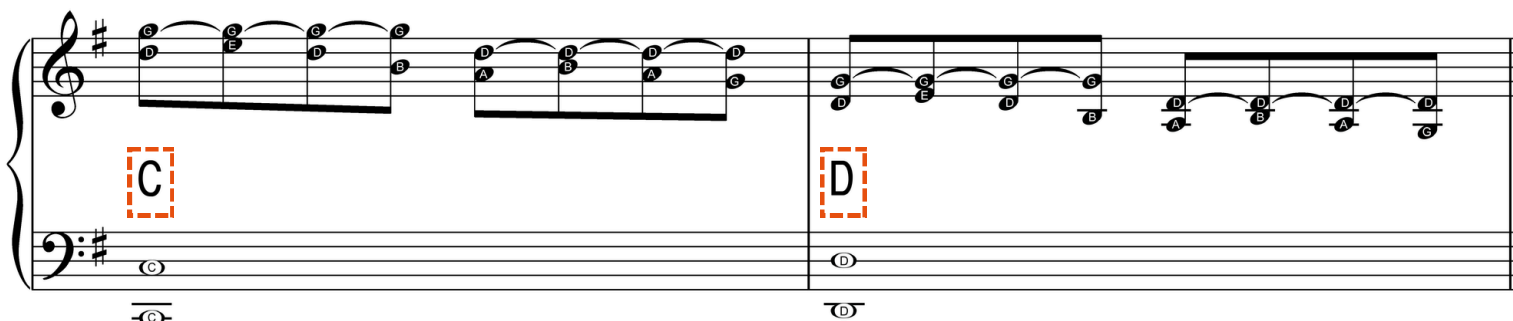


By inverting the triad, we create a shape that flows more smoothly under the fingers, making it easier to **connect ideas** and build more natural-sounding fills.

Now we'll add a colour note to each inversion of the G major triad, creating a pattern that brings the idea to life.



"You'll have even more fun once you start trying this fill over other chords in the key!"



Step #3

Add Rhythm



video 5:30

Now we're giving the fill some **movement** with a bit of rhythm. Even with the same notes, a simple groove can bring it to life.

Play this rhythmic fill over a new set of chords — **vi, ii, and bVII** — and notice how it transforms the progression.

Don't forget — you can swap between the fill and sustained chords, and add your own **variations** to keep things interesting!